Inclusive Language

In short

Choose words that respect everyone, whatever their disability, race, gender, age, or wealth. Don’t use disability words in a negative way, like ‘lame’ or ‘crazy’. Use neutral words like ‘everyone’ instead of ‘guys’, and write in plain language.

What is it for?

Inclusive language means using words that respect everyone. It avoids words that leave out, sideline, or put down groups of people, for example because of disability, race, gender, sexuality, age, or wealth.

In accessibility, language is a critical part of the user experience. Non-inclusive language creates significant barriers, making people feel unwelcome, unseen, or disrespected. These barriers include:

- Ableist language (for example, 'lame', 'crazy', 'blind spot') uses disability as a negative metaphor, which can be offensive and alienating
- Biased or gendered terms (for example, 'salesman', 'guys') can exclude people who don't identify with those terms
- Complicated jargon or sayings can be real barriers for people with cognitive disabilities, people who don't speak English as a first language, or people who find reading hard
- Using labels (for example, 'the disabled') defines people by their condition rather than as individuals

This is a communication practice, not a technical feature. It is fully supported and encouraged across all platforms and forms of communication.

How to support it

To ensure your language is inclusive, you must be conscious, precise, and empathetic in your word choices.

Use person-first language (for example, 'a person with vision loss') unless a group or individual expresses a preference for identity-first language (for example, 'an autistic person'). If you're not sure, person-first is often a safer starting point. The Deaf community generally prefers identity-first language (for example, 'Deaf people').

Avoid ableist metaphors. Instead of 'that idea is lame', say 'that idea is underdeveloped'. Instead of 'fell on deaf ears', say 'the feedback was ignored'.

Use neutral terms. Opt for 'everyone', 'team', or 'you all' instead of 'guys'. Use 'parent' instead of 'mother' or 'father', and 'partner' instead of 'husband', 'wife', 'boyfriend', or 'girlfriend' if you don't know.

Be specific and clear. Avoid jargon and write in plain language. Clearly describe functionality without assuming ability (for example, instead of 'Click here', use 'Select the Submit button').

Useful links

- Home Office Design System: Inclusive language
- Harder than you think: developing an inclusive language guide
- The Quick Guide to Inclusive Language